

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A263961, proved by transfer matrix

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Abstract

OEIS A263961 counts the arrangements of $0, 1, \dots, LW - 1$ in a grid of $W = 4$ rows in which every value moves from its home cell by an index change on a short list, and it carries an empirical recurrence of order 15 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is decidable rather than empirical. Such an arrangement is a perfect matching between cells and values, and because a value's row moves by at most $R = 1$, the matching splits into independent decisions row by row: after the cells of rows $0, \dots, i$ are filled, every value whose home row is at most $i - R$ has been used, and only $2R$ home rows are partly used. Carrying those as bitmasks makes the count a walk on $S = 256$ vertices, so it is C -finite and the conjectured recurrence is decided by a finite exact computation.

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1 The conjecture

OEIS A263961 is “Number of $(n+1) \times (3+1)$ arrays of permutations of $0..n^*4+3$ with each element having index change $(+,-,+,-)$ 0,0 1,1 or 1,2.”. It has offset 1 and begins

108, 2089, 95161, 3232688, 123067561, 4487054905, 165950022876, 6104375073457, ...

The entry states, as a conjecture contributed by its author and never marked settled:

Empirical: $a(n) = 59*a(n-1) - 800*a(n-2) - 5123*a(n-3) + 202521*a(n-4) - 1193960*a(n-5) - 8299248*a(n-6) + 121460288*a(n-7) - 182636544*a(n-8) - 3955605504*a(n-9) + 24437587968*a(n-10) - 38600179712*a(n-11) - 99925098496*a(n-12) + 461708984320*a(n-13) - 618475290624*a(n-14) + 274877906944*a(n-15)$

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Nov 10 2015 10:23:05, revision 6) this is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as proved.

2 The object is a matching

The grid has $W = 4$ rows across and holds each of $0, 1, \dots, LW - 1$ exactly once. The value v has a HOME cell, namely its place in the plain row-major filling, and putting v in cell (i, j) changes its index by $(i - h_i, j - h_j)$ where (h_i, h_j) is that home cell. The entry allows the index changes

$(i - h_i, j - h_j) \in \{(-1, -2), (-1, -1), (-1, 1), (-1, 2), (0, 0), (1, -2), (1, -1), (1, 1), (1, 2)\},$

the list being the entry's own, read with the sign convention its wording uses. An admissible arrangement is therefore exactly a perfect matching in the bipartite graph joining each cell to the values it may hold.

3 The matching is a walk

Let $R = 1$ be the largest $|i - h_i|$ on the list. A value whose home row is h can only be placed in rows $h - R, \dots, h + R$. So once the cells of rows $0, \dots, i$ are filled, every value with home row at most $i - R$ has been used up, and the only home rows that can be partly used are $i - R + 1, \dots, i + R$ — exactly $2R$ of them. Take as the state the tuple of $2R$ bitmasks recording which values of those home rows are already placed. One step fills the cells of one further row, drawing each of its W values from a home row within R and at an allowed column offset, and the home row that closes at that step must come out full. Nonexistent home rows — before the first and after the last — are carried as full, which makes the starting and accepting states the same one.

Hence a is a walk count on $S = 256$ vertices,

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^{n+1} \tau,$$

the exponent fixed by the entry's own shape and checked against its published terms; in particular a is C -finite.

4 The proof

Lemma 1. *Let $q(t) = t^{15} - \sum_i c_i t^{15-i}$ be the characteristic polynomial of the conjectured recurrence. The residual $a(n) - \sum_i c_i a(n-i)$ equals $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ for the corresponding walk index j , so the recurrence holds from some point on if and only if $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau = 0$ for all large j ; and it is enough to examine $j < S$.*

Proof. Factor M^j out of $M^{j+15} - \sum_i c_i M^{j+15-i}$. For the bound, M^S is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S-1}$ by Cayley–Hamilton, so the numbers $u_j = \iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ obey the monic recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of M ; S consecutive zeros force every later one, and the last nonzero u_j pins the threshold exactly. $\square$

Theorem 2.

$a(n) = 59a(n-1) - 800a(n-2) - 5123a(n-3) + 202521a(n-4) - 1193960a(n-5) - 8299248a(n-6) + 121460288a(n-7)$
for every $n > 13$.

Proof. The vector $w = q(M)\tau$ was formed by 15 matrix–vector products in exact integer arithmetic and $\iota^\top M^j w$ evaluated for $j = 0, 1, \dots$, again exactly; those integers vanish from the index corresponding to $n = 13 + 1$ onwards and the run continued until the working vector was identically zero, settling every larger j at once. $\square$

5 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, before any of this was built the reading of the entry's wording was tested against the entries themselves by brute force: enumerating all 720 arrangements of a 2×3 grid gives 20, the first term of A263960, and the 3×2 grid gives 9, the first term of its transposed companion A263966. Second, the transfer model reproduces all 14 terms this entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic. That check earned its keep: the entries use two different sign conventions, “ $(\pm, \pm) a, b$ ” meaning each coordinate signed independently and “ $\pm(., .) a, b$ ” meaning the PAIR signed, where the second coordinate may itself be written negative. Reading the second as the first silently drops a displacement, and thirteen of the first twenty-three entries tested disagreed with their own data until the two were separated.

Third, the annihilation test of Lemma 1 was carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the whole vector rather than on a sampled prefix.

References

- [1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org>, 2026. Sequence A263961.
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- [4] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.